

Speeding sound

All sounds travel at the same speed, but they travel more quickly through solids and liquids than through gases. Supersonic jets fly faster than the speed of sound, so they can pass over you before you hear their sound.

When a supersonic jet breaks the speed of sound, it catches up with the sound waves in front of it and squashes them. As the air is squashed, it produces a sound called a "sonic boom".



The echo effect

Some animals use sound to communicate or to hunt. Dolphins "talk" by making clicks, barks and other sounds that other dolphins recognize. They also use clicks to find food – the sound bounces back off objects as an echo, so the dolphin can establish their shape and position. This is called echolocation.

When sounds bounce back, the dolphin can tell if the object is a yummy fish or another dolphin!

